

Guidelines for Those Assigned Talks at Assemblies or Conventions

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1. Your assignment is one of many talks designed to develop the overall assembly or convention theme. Please be careful to develop only the material that has been assigned to you. There is no substitute for getting to know your subject. Allow enough time to prepare thoroughly; do not procrastinate. We live in “critical times.” (2 Tim. 3:1) Many of our brothers and sisters are facing severe pressures and tests of faith. They come to assemblies and conventions to be refreshed and strengthened spiritually. Your thorough preparation and effective delivery of this part can do much to encourage them. Make your participation on the program a matter of prayer, and Jehovah will bless your efforts. After you finish your part, you may be requested to report to the circuit overseer or to the Chairman’s Office.

TIMING

2. Watch your timing! Develop the outline in the time designated for each heading. If you go overtime, the brothers who follow you will feel obliged to cut their presentations short, which could weaken the effectiveness of the program. Your entire talk—including interviews, demonstrations, and soliloquies—should all be completed within your overall time allotment. Timing for each section is indicated in the capitalized heading. Much time is lost on lengthy introductions. Your introduction should be brief and to the point.—*th* study 1.

USE OF SCRIPTURES

3. Not all cited scriptures need to be read. Give attention to scriptures that support the main points. Give the audience enough time to look up the scriptures. Suggestions on how to do this within the allotted time can be found in the *Ministry School* book, page 146, paragraphs 4-5.

4. So that the audience can follow along as you read scriptures, please use the *New World Translation*. There may be an occasion when you will want to quote the *New World Translation* and thereafter briefly show how another translation renders a phrase or a verse. You may use your good judgment in this regard, bearing in mind what is stated in *The Watchtower* of October 1, 1997, page 20, paragraph 15.

5. Additionally, some speakers have introduced scriptures by using catchy expressions such as “meet me at . . .” or “let us rendezvous at . . .” Please refrain from using such innovations. Neither should the audience be invited to read scriptures aloud with you. Instead, please follow the guidelines in the *Teaching* brochure, study 4.

DELIVERY

6. Speak extemporaneously. Do not read your talk to the audience. (*be* pp. 50, 166, 174-178) Although it is good to be conversational, the situation calls for projection, volume, and sense stress. On the other hand, guard against sounding bombastic.

7. The outline indicates the order of development of ideas; familiarize yourself with that order rather than changing it. Do not introduce outside material or personal viewpoints. Do not say that there is an important point that you would like to read word-for-word from the outline. Avoid illustrations that might offend some listeners.—*be* pp. 240-246.

8. Some convention speakers have, at times, deviated from the language of the program and used another language. With good motives, a speaker might have done this because he felt it would benefit the children who perhaps would grasp more readily the meaning of what was being said. While this practice allows some of the children to get a better understanding, it cuts off the majority who expect to be instructed in the designated language of the program. (1 Cor. 14:9) Also, out of respect for the principle of parental headship, it is inappropriate to counsel young ones while excluding many parents from understanding what is being communicated to their children.—Eph. 6:1, 2.

PARTICIPANTS

9. If your assignment calls for the use of participants, you will be responsible for selecting them. With regard to adult participants, only baptized publishers who are exemplary in every respect should be used. If your assignment calls for the use of children, baptized youths are preferred, if such are available. In seeking exemplary participants, always check first with their Congregation Service Committee. If the participant you are considering is a minor, discuss the matter with the minor's parents and obtain their permission before inviting him. Invite the minor's parents to be present at all rehearsals involving the minor, and invite them to accompany their child when checking in the morning of the program, during walk-throughs, and backstage during the assigned part.

10. If it is hard to locate participants who fit the description supplied in the material, contact the circuit overseer, as he may know who might be available. Do not use individuals whose past disfellowshipping, reproof, or questionable conduct could raise questions in the minds of some in the audience. Problems result when brothers do not use sound judgment when selecting participants. Therefore, select as participants only those who will enhance the program by their presence on the platform.

11. Advance preparation is particularly important when interviews or demonstrations are involved. The interviews should be natural, realistic, and practical. They should be presented in a conversational manner. Always maintain Christian dignity. Some interviews seem flat and appear canned or formalistic because those being interviewed labor at repeating a memorized presentation or they read their own experiences. The interviewer should know what he wants those being interviewed to relate, and he should lead them with appropriate questions so that their comments are natural and spontaneous.

12. Persons whom you interview should direct their comments to you rather than to the audience, but they should not repeat your name each time they answer. Replies should be specific and usually no more than 30 to 60 seconds long. Do not ask those you are interviewing to offer recommendations or to give advice to the audience, unless this is specifically directed in the outline. It is your responsibility to apply the points that illustrate, support, or clarify the main points.

DRESS AND GROOMING

13. All who appear on the program should dress and groom themselves “with modesty and soundness of mind.” (1 Tim. 2:9; 1 Cor. 10:31-33) In some lands and in some cultures, there are styles of formal dress that do not involve wearing a jacket or a tie. Such styles might commonly be worn by local government officials when they carry out official duties. These styles are acceptable for brothers presenting parts.

SYMPOSIUMS

14. Each talk in a symposium should end in the same manner for the sake of consistency. Time is utilized best when the audience applauds while the speaker is exiting. Therefore, rather than pausing after your conclusion, immediately introduce the next speaker and make your exit.

VISUAL AIDS

15. If the outline instructs you to speak while a video is played, you may tell the video crew during the walkthrough when to pause the video and when to restart it.

16. Simple, dignified visual aids can be effective. However, you should not project any moving video footage or still pictures, graphics, or artwork on screens or monitors unless directed to do so by the organization. As an exception, speakers at **sign-language** assemblies and conventions may display still pictures, graphics, artwork, or videos of scriptures. They may also make judicious use of other videos from our organization as visual teaching aids for the special needs of deaf audiences.

CONFIDENTIALITY

17. Please keep information concerning your part strictly confidential, discussing it with no one other than those participating with you on the program. Also, impress the importance of confidentiality on all who will be working with you. No information regarding this assignment should be disclosed, copied, or distributed by any means. To the extent possible, we want our brothers and sisters to learn of the points made and to hear the program first when they attend the assembly or convention.

WHEN VIDEO CAMERAS ARE USED

18. When video cameras are used, look directly into the camera as if you are conversing with a dear friend, making frequent, natural eye contact. However, if the camera is mounted from the ceiling or in the back of the auditorium, you should maintain audience contact with those in the front center section. Although most of your eye contact should be with the camera, you do not need to maintain constant eye contact with the camera. Doing so appears unnatural and can be unsettling to the audience. Rather, make occasional eye contact with audience members seated near the camera. Avoid sweeping turns of your head. Participants in demonstrations and interviews should not direct their comments to the camera.

19. Avoid overly dramatic gestures. Keep your gestures close to your body so that they will be visible on camera. Know your material well. If you are overly dependent on your notes, this will be obvious on a large video screen.

20. If at all possible, practice giving your talk into a video camera. Use your computer webcam or mobile device. This will help you to become comfortable speaking into a camera. Record yourself practicing your talk, and then watch the recording. Correct any mannerisms that are distracting or unnatural.